all Hindu women in 2015 to 'produce four children'[139] to the then BJP UP vice president Dayashankar Singh comparing BSP chief Mayawati to a 'prostitute' in 2016,[140] there are enough examples of regional party leaders expressing objectionable views. Yet, the BJP has done dramatically well with women voters under Modi because of wider changes it made on women's representation and its overall discourse, as this chapter has outlined.

In tandem with the official shift in the BJP's positioning, the RSS's views on women also changed over time. In the 1960s, Golwalkar had extolled the ideal of a woman as a mother and wife, upholding traditional cultural norms. In recent years, by contrast, the Sangh has taken progressive and assertive positions on women's roles outside the family. In March 2016, it passed a resolution calling for eliminating restrictions on women in Hindu temples, saying that in religious matters 'both men and women are considered to be equal partners'. The RSS also supported women priests.[141] When Walter Andersen and Sridhar Damle updated their study of the RSS in 2018, they found that married members of the Sangh's women-affiliate body, the Rashtra Sevika Samiti, 'tended to describe themselves and their husbands (almost always RSS members) as equal partners, both in terms of managing family matters and in their respective civic lives'.[142] Like the BJP, the Rashtriya Sevika Samiti talks up the idea of women taking on combat roles and encourages such activities. An account of this by BJP Mahila Morcha leader Priti Gandhi in *Organiser* is instructive: 'With a strong belief that women are by no standards the weaker gender, the Rashtriya Sevika Samiti trains their Sevikas not only in outdoor sports but also teaches them skills like horse riding and sword fighting which help them develop their physical capacity and are confidence-building exercises. The Samiti recognises and celebrates the inherent qualities of a women —"Matrutva", i.e. Universal motherhood, "Kartrutva", or Efficiency and Social Activism and "Netrutva", i.e. Leadership. An exemplary mother like Jijabai, a capable administrator like Ahilyabai Holkar and a brave, fearless leader like Rani Lakshmibai of Jhansi are the role models of Sevikas.'[143]